

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

CHICAGO PUBLIC SCHOOLS



Classroom warfare

A top mayoral adviser told the city's school board he wanted CEO Pedro Martinez out by late September, memo shows, as the fight over his employment hits a boiling point

By Nell Salzman, Gregory Royal Pratt and Alice Yin | Chicago Tribune

Mayor Brandon Johnson's top labor adviser told board leaders at Chicago Public Schools that the mayor expected CEO Pedro Martinez to be out by Sept. 26, according to an internal memo obtained by the Tribune.

In a Sept. 12 email sent to Jianan Shi and Elizabeth Todd-Breland, the board's president and vice president at the time, Deputy Mayor for Labor Relations Bridget Early wrote, "Here's what lies ahead for the Board for the remainder of this term: CEO out by 9/26 ... Land contract, current leadership is not on track to getting this done before a strike."

Early's email laid out a series of "talking points" she said included "board expectations from the mayor."

As her last bullet point under the section for board member talking points, Early wrote: "Exit option — I have told the Mayor that I am committed to landing these items before the end of the term. It is okay if this is a lot to take on. If this feels like too much, we can work on an exit plan."

It's unclear if Shi and Todd-Breland — who ultimately did not move on Martinez's employment and resigned with the rest of Johnson's seven-member school board in October — replied. Shi declined to comment. Todd-Breland did not immediately respond to a request for comment on Thursday about the memo.

The mayor's office has refused to provide the full email via public records requests, but the Tribune obtained an unredacted copy this week. Johnson's chief of staff, Cristina Pacione-Zayas, was also included

Turn to Martinez, Page 4

MARTINEZ MUM ON FUTURE AS OTHERS SEEK DELAY: Chicago Public Schools chief Pedro Martinez didn't address the controversy Thursday surrounding a special board of education meeting called to oust him, instead focusing on congratulating the Luther Burbank Elementary School community for earning a rare designation in being inclusive of students with disabilities as a Special Olympics Unified Champion School. Meanwhile, Ald. Debra Silverstein, 50th, is asking the board to reschedule Friday evening's special meeting — where the agenda includes two explicit options to either fire Martinez or offer him a settlement. **Chicagoland, Page 4**

The tension between Chicago Public Schools CEO Pedro Martinez and Mayor Brandon Johnson continues to mount as a leaked memo reportedly shows Johnson wanted Martinez out by the end of September. Martinez is seen above at a Special Olympics event Thursday at Luther Burbank Elementary School on the city's Northwest Side. **BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Amazon drivers on strike in Skokie, beyond

Contractors who deliver packages seek contract

By Robert Channick and Talia Soglin
Chicago Tribune

Hundreds of drivers at an Amazon facility in Skokie launched a strike Thursday morning, potentially disrupting holiday deliveries in an effort to get the online retailing giant to recognize their affiliation with the Teamsters union and negotiate a labor contract.

The walkout at the Skokie delivery station and six other facilities nationwide was planned to begin at 5 a.m., with workers at other Amazon locations "prepared to join them," the Teamsters said in a news release Wednesday night.

"If your package is delayed during the holidays, you can blame Amazon's insatiable greed," Teamsters President Sean O'Brien said in the news release. "We gave Amazon a clear deadline to come to the table and do right by our members. They ignored it."

Amazon has refused to recognize the fledgling Teamsters union affiliation

Turn to Amazon, Page 5



Amazon delivery drivers strike Thursday outside the facility in Skokie. Drivers said they are frustrated by Amazon's insistence that they are not company employees, and they hoped their walkout would bring the retail giant to the bargaining table. **ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

PLANT SAFETY: At least two internal Amazon studies found a link between how quickly the online retailer's warehouse workers perform tasks and workplace injuries, but the company rejected many safety recommendations out of concern the proposed changes might curb productivity, according to a U.S. Senate committee report. **Business, Page 3**

House rejects Trump budget

Next steps are uncertain as the deadline looms to avoid federal shutdown

By Lisa Mascaro and Kevin Freking
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — The House rejected President-elect Donald Trump's new plan Thursday to fund federal operations and suspend the debt ceiling a day before a government shutdown, as Democrats refused to accommodate his sudden demands and the quick fix cobbled together by Republican leaders.

In a hastily convened vote punctuated by angry outbursts over the self-made crisis, the lawmakers failed to reach the two-thirds threshold needed for passage — but House Speaker Mike Johnson appeared determined to try again before Friday's midnight deadline.

"We're going to do the right thing here," Johnson said ahead of the vote. But he didn't even get a majority, with the bill failing 174-235.

The outcome proved a massive setback for Trump and his billionaire ally, Elon Musk, who rampaged against Johnson's bipartisan compromise, which Republicans and Democrats had reached earlier to prevent a Christmastime government shutdown.

It provides a preview of the turbulence ahead when Trump returns to the White House with Republican control of the House and Senate. During his first term, Trump led Republicans into the longest government shutdown in history during the 2018 Christmas season, and interrupted the holidays in 2020 by tanking a

Turn to Budget, Page 9

Immigration drives slight hike in state population

Increase outpaces rest of the Midwest, census says, though many still leaving

By Robert McCoppin
Chicago Tribune

Illinois gained nearly 68,000 people from 2023 to 2024, reversing a recent trend of population losses, the U.S. Census Bureau reported Thursday. Much of the increase was due to an influx of migrants, a trend that played out across the country.

The increase of 67,899, or 0.5%, was small and paled in comparison to the growth of 563,000 in Texas, but the numeric growth was the most in the Midwest.

Illinois had 12,710,158 residents as of July 1, the census estimated, ranking sixth among states nationally, still down by about 112,000 from 2020.

Nationwide, the population grew by nearly 1.0%, surpassing 340 million. That's the biggest increase since 2001 and a notable change from the record low growth rate of 0.2% in 2021. The growth was driven primarily by rising international migration, which affected every state.

Turn to Census, Page 2

Fuentes claims he was targeted

Cops in Berwyn killed a man wanted for a triple homicide after a pursuit that began on the block where far-right streamer Nick Fuentes lives. **Chicagoland, Page 4**

Police, malpractice suits settled

Cook County approved three more large settlements on Thursday — accounting for a fraction of the \$120 million it has approved so far this year. **Chicagoland, Page 5**

One hectic Disney origin story

"Mufasa: The Lion King" is a wild tale told in a distracting visual style, but it will do the job for families looking to avoid a third viewing of "Moana 2" or "Wicked." **A+E**

TODAY'S WEATHER



High 36 Low 17

Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 12

\$4.00 city and suburbs and elsewhere
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